

The Vista Dilemma

It's out—but is it what you should be switching to at work?

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As we write this, obsessing over Windows Vista is the order of the day. Will it kill your PC? How much better than XP is it, anyway? Will the Aero interface ever stop looking pretty? When it launched to businesses on November 30, nobody expected its sales to turn out they way they did—Vista surpassed Windows 2000's first-month sales, and came quite close to XP's. The appeal for the home user is quite obvious, but what is driving businesses to run after the new OS?

THE BURNING QUESTION

If you've been reading the news, you've no doubt read Microsoft's proud "Vista is the most secure Windows yet," and Symantec's sceptical "Yeah, right." Vista's focus on security can't be argued, though—from soliciting the US National Security Agency (NSA) for help, to the ridiculous number of features to protect you from the Bad Guys™. Here's what you get:

UAC

User Account Control (UAC) is designed to prevent potentially malicious programs or operations from running without your authorisation. When turned on, UAC verifies even file renames and deletes—the take-no-chances approach. In the first preview and beta releases, this feature was perhaps the most annoying thing about the OS—imagine having to go through seven steps just to rename a file! It evolved to be less of a pain by RC2, but it's still lacking one feature we'd have thought critical—a "remember my choice for this operation" check box. The lack means that you'll have to authorise even a "trusted" program every time you run it—or just switch off UAC, of course. We're hoping to see more customisability for this feature in an update. Overall, it's a well-intended feature, and will even allow network administrators more control over user rights.

Windows Defender

This is a re-hashed version of Microsoft Anti-Spyware, and is a surprisingly impressive part of Vista. The interface is simple, and you can monitor your system very granularly. We expected something as barebones as Windows Firewall, but this tool is as good as third-party anti-spyware.

BitLocker Drive Encryption

As the name suggests, BitLocker encrypts the data on your hard drive and blocks access to it unless authenticated by a Trusted Platform Module (TPM)—basically a microchip that is used as a "key" to your data. The TPM may be a chip on your motherboard or even a USB key—so if, say, your laptop is lost or stolen, there's no need to worry about your sensitive data. Oddly, though, this feature isn't a part of Windows Vista Business—you'll have to buy Enterprise or Ultimate for it. We're told Microsoft's research pointed more towards it being a feature for large enterprises.

IE7's Protected Mode

Under Vista, IE7 will run in its own low-privilege application environment, and ActiveX controls are downloaded into a virtual directory—if malicious

ActiveX controls do get in, they run in a virtual environment where they can't do any harm. There's also the phishing filter, which should prevent you or your employees from losing your sensitive information to online frauds.

Verdict

Out of the box, Vista is undoubtedly the most secure Windows—but *nobody* uses Windows without third-party security software, and this is where the snags come in. Vista's PatchGuard technology prevents any software getting into its kernel, including trusted security software. As a result, any software that *does* manage to break into the kernel has full access to the system, and has nothing to fear from security tools—and Symantec reports that this has already happened. Microsoft has agreed to rectify this, but it's something we won't see as of

